Bilingual Archiving in a Box: Community Archiving across Languages

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Building on the broader work of the Archivo de Respuestas Emergencias de Puerto Rico / Emergency Response Archive of Puerto Rico (AREPR), this presentation will showcase the release of our project, Bilingual Archiving in a Box (BArch Box). Consisting of guides, manuals, and video tutorials on community archiving, BArch Box is a bilingual community archiving toolkit designed for use by community groups, universities, and libraries across the Spanish- and English-speaking world. Over the past four years of the project, our technical team has produced numerous materials to facilitate the training of project members, community groups, and student researchers. These materials have been supplemented with additional resources and step-by-step tutorials and will be presented as an openly-available online collection. In this presentation we will discuss the formation of BArch Box, explore what materials are contained in the project, and envision possibilities for applying these resources to other community archiving projects.

The Archivo de Respuestas Emergencias de Puerto Rico / Emergency Response Archive of Puerto Rico (arepr.org) is a collaborative digital humanities project funded by grants from the Mellon Foundation and the National Endowment for the Humanities. AREPR employs the decolonial practice of post-custodial archiving to record stories of mutual aid organizations and individuals surviving and responding creatively to stratified disasters that have impacted the Puerto Rican archipelago in the last five years, including hurricanes, earthquakes, and the global pandemic of COVID-19. Over the course of two weeks in September 2017, Puerto Rico was successively impacted by a category 5 and a category 4 hurricane, Hurricanes Irma and María. The disaster, however, was not simply the hurricanes but also the events that followed. Notably, the disaster-response methods used—prioritization of urban centers, slow distribution of resources, and limited communication with those in need—placed the cultural legacy of Puerto Rico and the Caribbean under duress by leaving most Puerto Ricans to fend for themselves. Local residents were left to pick up the pieces on their own; as a result, the island largely depended upon community-based groups and their use of local traditions, oral knowledge, and community organizing.

In response, AREPR works with grassroots community organizations across Puerto Rico to highlight and share the role of mutual aid in disaster response. AREPR is committed to decolonial community archiving practices that build reciprocal, mutually beneficial relationships with and for our communities. Linda Tuhiwai Smith asserts that "the intellectual project of decolonizing has to set out ways to proceed through a colonizing world. It needs a radical compassion that reaches out, that seeks collaboration, and that is open to possibilities that can only be imagined as other things fall into place."[1] For AREPR, decolonial praxis is defined as "rejecting extractive forms of knowledge acquisition by relegating authority and control of collection processes, material selection, and dissemination strategies to the participating community organizations."[2] This approach includes practices like consent-based decision making, which ensures all parties are informed and in support of project developments; a hierarchical project structure, which recognizes that each member of our team has unique Building on the broader work of the Archivo de Respuestas Emergencias de Puerto Rico / Emergency Response Archive of Puerto Rico (AREPR), this presentation will showcase the release of our project, Bilingual Archiving in a Box (BArch Box). Consisting of guides, manuals, and video tutorials on community archiving, BArch Box is a bilingual community archiving toolkit designed for use by community groups, universities, and libraries across the Spanish- and English-speaking world. Over the past four years of the project, our technical team has produced numerous materials to facilitate the training of project members, community groups, and student researchers. These materials have been supplemented with additional resources and step-by-step tutorials and will be presented as an openly-available online collection. In this presentation we will discuss the formation of BArch Box, explore what materials are contained in the project, and envision possibilities for applying these resources to other community archiving projects.

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Notes

1. Linda Tuhiwai Smith. *Decolonizing Methodologies: Research and Indigenous Peoples*. London: Zed Books Ltd. 2012.
2. Christina Boyles, "Resilience, Recovery, and Refusal: The (Un)tellable Narratives of Post–María Puerto Rico," *Enculturation* 32 (November 2020), accessed December 2024, https://enculturation.net/resilience-recovery-refusal .
3. Linda Tuhiwai Smith. *Decolonizing Methodologies: Research and Indigenous Peoples*. London: Zed Books Ltd. 2012.
4. Christina Boyles, "Resilience, Recovery, and Refusal: The (Un)tellable Narratives of Post–María Puerto Rico," *Enculturation* 32 (November 2020), accessed December 2024, https://enculturation.net/resilience-recovery-refusal .

Bibliography

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Michelle Caswell, Ricardo Punzalan, and T-Kay Sangwand, "Critical Archival Studies: An Introduction," in "Critical Archival Studies," ed. Michelle Caswell, Ricardo Punzalan, and T-Kay Sangwand, special issue, *Journal of Critical Library and Information Studies* 1, no. 2 (2017), DOI:10.24242/jclis.v1i2.50